Political developments in the US also affected the pace of Sino-US rapprochement in 1976. There was little progress in an election year. The administration's frustration with Beijing's behavior was evident. Kissinger told the Pakistani foreign minister that Chinese criticism was giving both conservatives and liberals ammunition. Frustrated about the lack of reciprocity, he said that China was "tak[ing] a free ride."[81]

## The Carter-Desai Years (1977–1979)

The end of 1976 and early 1977 saw political changes in China, India, and the US. In China, Mao's death in September 1976 paved the way for developments that led to Deng emerging as the top Chinese leader. In the US, the November elections brought former Georgia governor Jimmy Carter to the White House in January 1977. And in India, Gandhi surprised many in January by calling for elections. The polls resulted in India's first-ever non–Congress Party government, led by Morarji Desai, now of the Janata Party.

For Delhi, Carter was something of an unknown, but the new American president was not unfamiliar with India. His mother Lillian had served there in the Peace Corps. Desai, in turn, was not a stranger to the US; he had traveled there multiple times as a minister and was seen as anticommunist. The two leaders would develop a personal relationship during Desai's two years in office, regularly exchanging letters that covered a range of issues, including China. That country factored in the relationship quite differently—in the early years of the Cold War, India had tried to persuade the US to develop a relationship with China; now it was Washington, concerned about Soviet influence in India, that was urging Delhi to improve relations with Beijing.

### *A New Chapter*

When Carter came to office, the prospects for relations with the emergency-era Gandhi government did not seem bright. His foreign policy platform had included an emphasis on democracy and nonproliferation—on both those fronts, India was considered a problem. But Carter and National Security Adviser Zbigniew Brzezinski did envision a place for India in their strategic framework. For them, while the US-Soviet bipolar competition